BEYOND CHIAVARI · FREE PLANNING KIT

Gala and Fundraiser Planning Kit

For nonprofit teams and volunteer committees planning a gala, benefit dinner, or auction fundraiser.

A fundraiser is a party with a purpose, and the details decide how much money you raise. This kit covers your committee, timeline, sponsorship tiers, auction planning, run of show, budget, volunteer roles, and donor follow-up. Use it to keep your team organized and your guests generous.

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Chairs, tables, linens, tents and more across Chicagoland, on one quote.

PART 1

Committee Roles and Timeline

Start 9 to 12 months out for a large gala. Smaller benefits can compress this to 4 to 6 months. Book a date early, since spring and fall Chicago calendars fill quickly.

9 to 12 months out

- [ ] Recruit a chair or co-chairs and a committee of 6 to 12 people.
- [ ] Set a fundraising goal and a net revenue target after expenses.
- [ ] Choose the event theme, format, and approximate guest count.
- [ ] Pick the date and avoid conflicts with other major Chicago-area galas and holidays.
- [ ] Tour and book the venue.
- [ ] Draft the budget and get board approval.

6 to 8 months out

- [ ] Create the sponsorship packages and begin outreach to sponsors.
- [ ] Recruit an honoree, keynote speaker, or emcee.
- [ ] Book the caterer, DJ or band, photographer, and AV team.
- [ ] Reserve rentals: tables, chairs, linens, glassware, staging, lighting, and tent if needed.
- [ ] Start collecting auction items and experiences.
- [ ] Set up an online ticketing and donation platform.

4 to 5 months out

- [ ] Send save-the-dates to your donor list.
- [ ] Confirm sponsor commitments and logos for printed materials.
- [ ] Plan the program, run of show, and appeal moment.
- [ ] Order invitations and sponsor recognition signage.
- [ ] Choose the auction method: silent, live, mobile bidding, or all three.
- [ ] Book auctioneer if holding a live auction.

2 to 3 months out

- [ ] Send formal invitations with ticket and table purchase options.
- [ ] Follow up personally with top donors and sponsors.
- [ ] Finalize auction items and write descriptions.
- [ ] Design the program book and ads.
- [ ] Confirm the menu and dietary tracking.
- [ ] Draft the seating plan strategy for sponsors, board members, and honorees.

1 month out

- [ ] Send reminder emails and texts to unregistered supporters.
- [ ] Finalize the guest list and table assignments.
- [ ] Print bid sheets, signage, and programs.
- [ ] Test the mobile bidding platform and payment processing.
- [ ] Confirm volunteer shifts and send training materials.
- [ ] Share the run of show with every vendor and speaker.

1 week out

- [ ] Confirm final headcount with the caterer and rental company.
- [ ] Prepare the guest check-in list and name badges.
- [ ] Pack the day-of kit and cash box.
- [ ] Hold a volunteer briefing.
- [ ] Check the forecast and finalize the coat check and weather plan.
- [ ] Pre-write thank-you messages for sponsors and donors.

Day of

- [ ] Inspect the rental delivery and count tables, chairs, linens, and glassware.
- [ ] Set up auction tables, bid sheets, and display items.
- [ ] Test microphones, projector, and mobile bidding.
- [ ] Brief volunteers and staff at the venue.
- [ ] Greet sponsors and VIP guests first.
- [ ] Keep the program on time and the appeal moment short and powerful.

After the event

- [ ] Schedule the rental pickup and count items returned.
- [ ] Pay winning bidders' receipts and distribute auction items.
- [ ] Send thank-you messages to everyone within 48 hours.
- [ ] Reconcile revenue and expenses within two weeks.
- [ ] Hold a committee debrief and document lessons learned.

PART 2

Sponsorship Tiers

Sample structure only. The amounts are illustrations. Set your own levels based on your donor base and goals.

Tier	Sample commitment	Typical benefits
Presenting sponsor	Highest level (for example $25,000+)	Naming rights, two reserved tables, speaking moment, logo on all materials, full-page program ad
Platinum	For example $15,000	Reserved table of 10, logo on signage and website, half-page ad, social media recognition
Gold	For example $10,000	Reserved table of 10, logo on signage, quarter-page ad, mention in the program
Silver	For example $5,000	Five tickets, name on signage, name in the program
Bronze	For example $2,500	Two tickets, name in the program
Table host	Price of one table	Seats for 8 or 10 guests, name on the table, recognition in the program
In-kind sponsor	Donated goods or services	Logo or name on signage, acknowledgment in the program, tax receipt where eligible

PART 3

Silent and Live Auction Checklist

PROCURING ITEMS

- [ ] Set a target number of items based on guest count, with roughly one item for every 4 to 5 guests.
- [ ] Ask local businesses, board members, and donors for experiences and goods.
- [ ] Prioritize unique experiences, travel, and exclusive access over generic gift baskets.
- [ ] Collect donation letters for tax purposes.
- [ ] Record the fair market value of each item.
- [ ] Photograph each item and write a short description.

SILENT AUCTION SETUP

- [ ] Set a starting bid at about 40 to 50 percent of retail value.
- [ ] Set bid increments and a buy-it-now option for popular items.
- [ ] Arrange tables with linens at the height guests can easily read.
- [ ] Print bid sheets and place pens at every table.
- [ ] Number each item and match the bid sheet.
- [ ] Set up mobile bidding with a clear link or QR code.
- [ ] Choose a closing time and announce it multiple times.

LIVE AUCTION

- [ ] Choose five to ten high-value items for the live auction.
- [ ] Hire a professional auctioneer or a charismatic volunteer.
- [ ] Rehearse the order of items and the opening bids.
- [ ] Prepare a fund-a-need appeal tied to a specific outcome.
- [ ] Assign spotters to watch the room and call bids.
- [ ] Build in time for the appeal after dinner while guests are attentive.

CHECKOUT

- [ ] Set up a checkout table near the exit with trained staff.
- [ ] Print or send receipts to winning bidders.
- [ ] Accept credit cards, mobile payments, and checks.
- [ ] Match winning bidders with items and arrange pickup or shipping.
- [ ] Keep a record of unsold items to reuse next year.

PART 4

Gala Run of Show

Sample for a 5:30 pm to 10:30 pm seated gala. Adjust to your venue and program.

Time	What happens	Who is in charge
10:00 am	Rental delivery: tables, chairs, linens, glassware, staging, lighting	Event chair or planner
1:00 pm	AV load-in and sound check	AV team
2:00 pm	Auction setup and signage	Auction volunteers
3:30 pm	Caterer arrives	Caterer
4:30 pm	Volunteer briefing and positions assigned	Volunteer lead
5:00 pm	Final walk-through and tech rehearsal	Event chair
5:30 pm	Doors open, check-in, silent auction opens	Check-in team
6:30 pm	Seating announcement, welcome from emcee	Emcee

Time	What happens	Who is in charge
6:45 pm	Dinner service begins	Caterer
7:15 pm	Mission moment or video	Executive director
7:30 pm	Honoree presentation	Emcee and honoree
7:45 pm	Live auction	Auctioneer
8:15 pm	Fund-a-need appeal	Executive director and auctioneer
8:30 pm	Silent auction closes, dessert and coffee	Auction team and caterer
8:45 pm	Dancing or entertainment begins	DJ or band
9:30 pm	Auction checkout opens	Checkout team
10:15 pm	Thank-you and send-off	Chair
10:30 pm	Load-out and rental breakdown	Vendors and volunteers

PART 5

Gala Budget Split

A typical starting point. Aim for the event to raise much more than it costs. Chicago-area venue and catering costs vary widely.



Category	Share	Your budget: $_____	Tip
Venue and rentals	20%	$_____	Negotiate nonprofit rates and ask what is included with the venue fee.
Food and beverage	40%	$_____	Ask for a nonprofit discount and confirm service charge and gratuity.
Entertainment and AV	12%	$_____	Include microphones, projection, lighting, and a technician.
Printing and decor	8%	$_____	Use sponsor ads to offset the cost of the program book.
Auction and technology	6%	$_____	Mobile bidding platforms charge a fee or a percentage.
Marketing and invitations	5%	$_____	Email and social media reach your donors for less.
Staffing, security, and parking	4%	$_____	Valet and security are often required in downtown venues.
Contingency	5%	$_____	Hold this until the event is over.

PART 6

Volunteer Roles

Assign each role a lead and a backup. Brief everyone one week before.

BEFORE DOORS OPEN

- [ ] Setup crew: place tables, chairs, linens, table numbers, and centerpieces.
- [ ] Signage lead: place directional signs, sponsor signs, and menu cards.
- [ ] Auction setup lead: arrange items, bid sheets, and descriptions.
- [ ] AV liaison: connect with the AV team and run the slides.
- [ ] Vendor greeter: meet each vendor at the loading dock.

DURING THE EVENT

- [ ] Check-in greeters: welcome guests, find names, hand out badges and bid numbers.
- [ ] Coat check attendants: manage coats and bags, especially from November to March.
- [ ] Auction spotters: call out bids in the live auction.
- [ ] Checkout team: process payments and hand out items.
- [ ] Table hosts: help guests find seats and introduce people.
- [ ] Photographer liaison: point out sponsors, honorees, and key moments.
- [ ] Floater: answer questions and fix problems fast.

AFTER THE EVENT

- [ ] Pack up auction items and unsold goods.
- [ ] Collect centerpieces, signs, and decor.
- [ ] Count rental items and stack them for pickup.
- [ ] Gather lost-and-found items.
- [ ] Take out the trash and leave the room clean.

PART 7

Post-event Donor Follow-up

WITHIN 48 HOURS

- [ ] Send a thank-you email to every guest, sponsor, and volunteer.
- [ ] Post photos and a short thank-you on social media.
- [ ] Send tax receipts for gifts and ticket purchases.
- [ ] Share the preliminary fundraising total.

WITHIN 2 WEEKS

- [ ] Call or write personal notes to top donors and sponsors.
- [ ] Send a handwritten note to the honoree and keynote speaker.
- [ ] Share a short impact story showing how funds will be used.
- [ ] Update the donor database with every gift and bid.
- [ ] Reconcile revenue and expenses.

WITHIN 3 MONTHS

- [ ] Send a progress update to donors showing results.
- [ ] Invite sponsors to a debrief or renew early.
- [ ] Survey guests about the event experience.
- [ ] Document lessons learned and update the playbook.
- [ ] Save the date for next year's event.

PART 8

Gala Planning Worksheet

EVENT NAME AND THEME

DATE AND VENUE

FUNDRAISING GOAL AND NET TARGET

COMMITTEE CHAIR AND PHONE

EXPECTED GUEST COUNT

HONOREE OR KEYNOTE SPEAKER

PRESENTING SPONSOR

CATERER AND MENU

AV AND ENTERTAINMENT VENDORS

RENTAL COMPANY AND DELIVERY WINDOW

AUCTION METHOD AND PLATFORM

VOLUNTEER LEAD AND PHONE

WEATHER AND COAT CHECK PLAN

FOLLOW-UP DEADLINES

NEXT STEP

Get every rental on one quote

Pick chairs, tables, linens, dinnerware, tents and decor from Chicago-area rental companies and see prices as you build your list at beyondchiavari.com/quote. Want a second set of eyes on your plan? Book a free planning call at beyondchiavari.com/book.

Planning rules of thumb only. Confirm counts, rules and timing with your venue and vendors. © Beyond Chiavari. Free to print and share for personal planning.